KANT & FREE WILL | PRESLEY JASON COLIN FINN

PART I Earlier views and the problem Kant inherits

DESCARTES



- Freedom is self-evident
- We can withhold assent
- God foreordains events

→

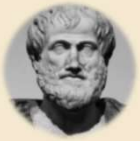
SPINOZA



- Desires have causes
- We know our wishes
- Not what causes them

→

ARISTOTLE



- Experience and causes
- Habits shape action
- Deliberation matters

→

HUME



- Constant conjunction
- No perceived necessary tie
- Induction problem

Central question: If our choices have causes, can we still be free?

PART II A Kant: The Second Analogy and the apparent threat to free will (A189–211/B232–256)

Perceive events → **Successive perceptions** → **Objective vs. subjective order** → **Time is not directly perceived** → **Apprehension is insufficient** → **Causality sets the rule** → **Every alteration has a cause** → **Free will seems excluded**

Interpretive tension: If a free choice must have no natural cause, the Second Analogy appears to rule it out.

PART II B Kant: How the limits of knowledge leave freedom thinkable (B1–B287 and Preface)

A priori knowledge → **Space & time shape experience** → **Appearances ≠ things in themselves** → **Categories organize experience** → **Causality applies to appearances** → **One lawful natural world** → **Necessity within experience** → **Freedom not disproved**

KEY DISTINCTION Natural causality governs human actions as **appearances**. It does not establish that things in themselves are **determined** in the same way.